

A MORAL DICTIONARY

An English reference of moral values, concepts and terms

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DRAFT FOR REVIEW

First edition · December 2025

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Foreword

Today's society is marked by growing complexity, moral ambiguity and polarization. Professionals, managers and administrators face questions of diversity, inclusion and transgressive behaviour in the workplace, but also far-reaching issues such as climate change and digitalization, in which moral considerations play a central role. Yet a shared language for making those moral dimensions discussable is often missing. This hampers not only the quality of our decisions, but also our ability to speak and think about doing “good work”.

Research shows that moral formation calls for active guidance, dialogue and access to a richer moral vocabulary. The professionals of tomorrow often turn out to have only a limited repertoire of concepts for putting their moral intuitions and considerations into words. A limited vocabulary leads to a shallow or merely instrumental way of handling moral questions, whereas a broader language creates room for nuance, reflection and dialogue.

At the same time, society increasingly asks for professionals, managers and administrators who are not only technically competent but also morally literate: doctors who have the language to speak about care and dignity, administrators who can name the tension between responsibility and justice, and teachers who can make their values explicit in their pedagogical choices. The absence of a shared moral language increases the risk of miscommunication and conflict, while a rich moral vocabulary can foster understanding, dialogue and more responsible decision-making.

This little moral dictionary offers an urgent and fresh contribution: it supports awareness and the development of morally sound professional conduct. It is not an exhaustive list of morally charged words, but rather a practical instrument, broadly usable in education, governance and professional practice. A number of exercises have been added as well, so that the dictionary can be put to work in teaching, at work, or simply at home with family and friends. We hope it makes for a rich and rewarding experience.

The Research Group for Ethical Practice (*Lectoraat Ethisch Werken*)

A note for this English edition

This dictionary began in Dutch. Rendering it into English turned out to be more than translation: ethics and morality are culturally shaped, and a language foregrounds the moral concepts its speakers most need. Where English carries a morally charged idea that Dutch does not name in a single word — belonging, safeguarding, stewardship, fairness as distinct from honesty — we have added an entry with a short cultural note. A small number of contested terms (woke, cancel culture, virtue signalling, political correctness) are included too, described neutrally rather than endorsed, precisely because a facilitator guiding a moral conversation needs the vocabulary to name them without taking sides.

CULTURAL NOTE *Entries in an amber panel are English-language concepts without a close single-word Dutch equivalent.*

CONTESTED TERM *Entries in a grey panel are contested terms, described as neutrally as possible rather than endorsed.*

The dictionary — A to Z

A

Acceptance — Receiving people, situations or circumstances as they are, without resistance or judgment.

Accountability — Giving an account of one's actions, decisions and their consequences.

Adaptability — The capacity to respond flexibly and effectively to changing circumstances.

Aesthetic sensibility — Responsiveness to beauty that evokes pleasure or admiration.

Aggression — Hostile or threatening conduct towards others, whether in word or deed.

→ **see also:** *Unwanted behaviour, Transgressive behaviour*

Alertness — Being quick to notice and respond attentively to signals or changes.

Altruism — Concern for the welfare of others, often at the expense of one's own interest.

Amorality — Standing outside morality; making no distinction between right and wrong.

Anger — An intense emotion in response to perceived injustice or a violation of values and norms.

→ **see also:** *Wrath*

Approachability — Being open to account for oneself and to receive feedback — someone others can readily address.

Ardour — Enthusiasm and fervent commitment to a cause or activity.

Attentiveness — The ability to focus consciously and deliberately on people, tasks or situations.

Authenticity — Being genuine, sincere and true to oneself.

Autonomy — The capacity or right to make decisions independently; self-governance.

Awareness — The capacity for reflection and for perceiving oneself and one's surroundings.

B

Backbiting — Speaking maliciously of someone in their absence.

Balance — A state of equilibrium — between interests, duties or emotions, for example.

Beauty — A quality that evokes aesthetic or emotional pleasure.

Belonging — The felt sense of being fully accepted and valued in a group as oneself.

CULTURAL NOTE *Keystone of Anglo-Saxon D&I discourse ('diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging'); Dutch often stops at 'inclusie' and lacks a core word for the affective sense of belonging.*

Beneficence — Goodness and generous action for the benefit of others.

Boundaries (personal) — The personal or social limits of what is acceptable; conduct that breaches them fails to respect the person.

→ **see also:** *Transgressive behaviour, Consent*

Broad-mindedness — Openness to new ideas, perspectives and views.

Bullying — Repeatedly tormenting or harassing another person.

→ **see also:** *Unwanted behaviour, Transgressive behaviour*

Buoyancy — A friendly, forgiving and patient disposition.

C

Calmness — A calm, controlled bearing in action and emotion; mental and physical repose.

Cancel culture — Publicly calling out and withdrawing support from people or organizations seen to have acted unacceptably — read by critics as disproportionate punishment, by defenders as overdue accountability.

CONTESTED TERM *Whether it names a real phenomenon or is a rhetorical device to deflect criticism is itself debated. Anglo-American, taken into Dutch untranslated.*

Care (attentive) — Attention and effort devoted to the wellbeing of others.

Carefreeness — Being free of worry and tension.

Categorical imperative — Kant's principle that one should act only on rules one could will to become a universal law.

Caution — Acting carefully and thoughtfully to avoid risks.

Certainty — Confidence and assurance about knowledge, a situation or an outcome.

Charity (philanthropy) — Active support or help for others without self-interest.

Citizenship — Participating actively and responsibly in society.

→ **see also:** *Participation*

Civility (good manners) — Refinement and courtesy in conduct.

Clarity — Clearness in communication and intentions.

Code of conduct — Guidelines setting out how one ought to behave in a professional or social context, respecting values and norms.

Collegiality — Supportive, helpful conduct towards colleagues, placing the shared interest above one's own.

Commitment — Active, sincere participation in, or connection with, others or a cause.

Commonality — Sharing interests, values or goals with others.

Companionship — Being present with, and interacting with, others.

Compassion — Feeling with, and caring for, others; being moved by another's wellbeing and wishing to help.

→ **see also:** *Mercy, Pity, Empathy*

Compliance — Adherence to rules, laws or guidelines, often externally imposed.

Composure (self-control) — Being able to keep one's emotions and impulses under control.

Comradeship — Friendship and support within a group or community.

Confidentiality — Keeping sensitive information private.

→ **see also:** *Privacy, Discretion*

Conflict of interest — A situation in which private interests could improperly sway the performance of a duty or role.

CULTURAL NOTE *Cornerstone of Anglo-American governance; 'belangenverstrengeling' covers it, but the disclosure-oriented, analytical treatment is imported.*

Conformity — Adapting to the rules, norms or expectations of a group or society.

Congruence — The degree to which conduct aligns with, and is in harmony with, one's convictions.

Connectedness — A sense of coherence and relationship with others.

Connecting (uniting) — The quality of bringing people together and strengthening relationships.

Conscience — The inner sense of right and wrong by which one judges one's own deeds.

Conscience-based distress — A state of acute suffering caused by a clash between duty and conscience.

Note: closest professional term: 'moral distress'

Conscientious objection — An objection raised on moral or philosophical grounds.

Conscientiousness — Acting with care, diligence and a sense of duty.

Consensus-orientation — An orientation towards agreement and joint decision-making.

Consent — Freely given, informed and revocable agreement, especially where power or intimacy is involved.

CULTURAL NOTE *The modern affirmative-consent framing is Anglo-American; directly relevant to transgressive behaviour and social safety.*

Consequentialist ethics — An ethical approach in which the moral worth of an act depends on its outcome.

→ **see also:** *Deontology, Utilitarianism, Intention*

Consideration — Showing attention and respect for others in one's decisions and conduct.

Consistency — The extent to which conduct is logical and stable, without contradiction.

Contentment — A feeling of fulfilment and wellbeing.

Continuity — Coherence and constancy in actions, processes or policy.

Cooperation — Working jointly towards a goal or project.

Cooperativeness — A willingness to work together towards shared goals.

Cordiality — A warm, genial and friendly manner towards others.

Correctness — Accuracy and rightness in conduct or communication.

Courage — The capacity to face danger, fear or hardship in order to act rightly.

→ **see also:** *Valour, Heroism, Moral courage*

Courtesy — Respectful and considerate conduct towards others.
Cowardice — A failure of courage; shrinking from danger or duty.
Craftsmanship — A high level of skill and expertise in a profession.
Critical thinking — Assessing information and situations analytically, including their ethical implications.
→ **see also:** *Gut feeling, Judgment*
Curiosity — Interest and a desire to learn and discover.

D

Dedication — Enthusiasm and passion for an activity or ideal.
Demagoguery — The art of misleading people, especially through rhetorical manipulation.
Democratic spirit — A system, or disposition, of equal voice and participation.
Deontology — The moral theory that an act is right when it fulfils duties and rules, regardless of consequences.
→ **see also:** *Consequentialist ethics, Intention, Duty*
Devotion — Active, loyal commitment to a goal or person.
Dialogue — An open exchange in which differing perspectives meet as equals.
Diligence — Zeal and careful effort in work or study.
Diplomacy — Handling people and situations with tact and good judgment.
Discipline — The capacity to impose order and rules on oneself and hold to them.
Discretion — Handling information or situations with care and confidentiality.
Discrimination — Making unjustified distinctions between people on grounds such as origin, sex, age or sexual orientation.
Disgust (moral) — A strong aversion to conduct seen as morally objectionable.
Diversity & inclusion — Diversity: the presence of differences (origin, age, gender). Inclusion: actively valuing and drawing on those differences in an equal environment.
→ **see also:** *Belonging, Equity*
Drive — Strong motivation and effort to achieve goals.
Duty — A moral obligation.
→ **see also:** *Deontology, Sense of duty*
Duty of care — The obligation to see to the wellbeing and safety of those within one's sphere of influence, and to take reasonable care not to harm those affected by one's actions.
Note: The English 'duty of care' also carries a common-law liability dimension the Dutch term lacks.

E

Earnestness — A serious, sincere disposition towards tasks and situations.
Empathy — The ability to enter into another's feelings and thoughts.
Equality — Recognizing that everyone has the same worth; fair and equal treatment.
→ **see also:** *Equity*

Equity — Treating people according to their differing needs so that outcomes are just — distinct from treating everyone identically.

CULTURAL NOTE *The equity/equality distinction is central to Anglo-Saxon diversity debate; Dutch 'gelijkheid/gelijkwaardigheid' does not encode it lexically.*

→ **see also:** *Equality*

Esteem (social standing) — The regard and respect someone enjoys within a group or society.

Ethical code — A formal document setting out an organization's or profession's norms, values and rules of conduct.

Ethical dilemma — A conflict requiring a choice between competing moral values that cannot both be honoured at once.

Ethical issues — Specific problems or questions calling for a moral judgment or ethical weighing.

Ethical principles — Fundamental rules or convictions that guide moral action.

Ethical reflection — Examining the moral rightness of one's own or others' actions and decisions.

Ethics — Critical reflection on morality — the body of norms and values determining right and wrong in human conduct.

Expertise — Professional knowledge and competence in a given field.

F

Fair play — Acting by the rules and in the spirit of fairness and respect, especially in cooperation or competition.

Fairness — Even-handed, just treatment and due process, giving each their proper due.

Note: English separates 'fairness' (just treatment) from 'honesty' (truth-telling), whereas Dutch 'eerlijk' fuses both. Fairness is often procedural, not only about outcomes.

Fame — Recognition and reputation earned through achievement or status.

Fellowship — A sense of connection and solidarity within a group.

Finality — Orientation towards a goal or ultimate outcome.

Finesse — The capacity to grasp and appreciate subtle differences and nuance.

Flexibility — The capacity to adapt to changing circumstances.

Flourishing — A period of optimal development, growth or success.

Forgiveness — The willingness to forgive others and to let go of blame; the counterpart to rancour.

→ **see also:** *Rancour*

Fortitude — Inner strength and resilience in thought and action.

Free-spokenness — Daring and openness in speaking or acting.

Freedom — A condition in which one can act or think without undue constraint.

G

Generosity — A readiness to give or share freely.

Gentleness — A gentle, forgiving and patient disposition.

Genuine interest — Showing sincere interest in others or in certain matters.

Grandiosity — An inflated sense of one's own importance or ability; self-overestimation bordering on hubris.

Gratitude — A sense of thankfulness towards someone who has done you good.

Greatness — A quality of being impressive or magnificent in character or deed.

Grit — Sustained perseverance and passion toward long-term goals, treated as a strength of character.

CULTURAL NOTE *American concept (Duckworth); frames perseverance as character, not temperament — 'doorzettingsvermogen' describes the behaviour without the virtue framing.*

→ **see also:** *Perseverance*

Guilt — A sense of responsibility for a wrong or failing.

Gut feeling — An intuitive judgment based on feeling rather than analysis.

→ **see also:** *Critical thinking*

H

Harmony — Balanced accord or cooperation between people or elements.

Hearing both sides (audi alteram partem) — The principle that no one should be judged without a fair opportunity to be heard and to answer what is alleged against them.

Helpfulness — A willingness to support or help others.

Heroism — Courage and resolve in overcoming danger or adversity.

Honesty — Being sincere, trustworthy and authentic, without lying or deceiving.

Honour — The high regard one receives from others or holds oneself worthy of; also a sense of personal pride.

Hope — The expectation or trust that something good will happen, despite uncertainty.

Hospitality — A readiness to welcome and support others.

Hubris — An excessively high opinion of oneself — 'pride comes before a fall'.

Human dignity — The inherent worth of every person, deserving of respect regardless of status or conduct.

Humaneness — Respect and care for others as fellow human beings.

Humility — Modesty in bearing and acknowledgment of one's own limitations.

I

Idealism — Orientation towards an ideal that approaches perfection and that one seeks to realize.

Imagination — The capacity to form creative and original ideas.

Immorality — Being contrary to morality; unethical conduct.

Impartiality — Acting without bias or conflict of interest; treating everyone equally.

→ **see also:** *Objectivity, Neutrality*

Improvement — A process of progress or optimization.

Inclusiveness — The quality of admitting and valuing everyone, regardless of differences.

Incorruptibility — Being honest and not open to bribery.

Independence — The capacity to think, act and decide for oneself, free of undue influence.

Informing (duty to inform) — The duty to give and to seek information honestly and completely.

Ingenuity — The capacity to devise creative solutions.

Innovation — The introduction of something new or improved.

Inspiration — Inspiring energy and dedication in one's work or actions.

Inspiring others — Kindling energy, purpose or belief in others.

Integral responsibility — Bearing responsibility for the whole, including the coherence between its parts or disciplines.

Integrity — Being honest, sincere and incorruptible; staying true to one's principles even when no one is watching.

Integrity of character — Completeness and consistency in character and conduct.

Intention — The aim or purpose behind an act. In ethics it bears its own moral weight: duty-based approaches weigh it heavily, consequentialist ones look past it to the outcome.

→ **see also:** *Deontology, Consequentialist ethics*

Intimacy — Closeness and deep connection with others.

Intimidation — Instilling fear in another, whether deliberately or through the effect of one's conduct or position.

Note: false friend: Dutch policy usage often means what English calls 'harassment' (repeated unwanted conduct), whereas English 'intimidation' is narrower.

Intrinsic motivation — The inner drive to act according to one's own values and convictions.

J

Judgment (discernment) — The capacity to make considered decisions and to distinguish between sources and options.

→ **see also:** *Wisdom, Prudence*

Justice — Giving each their due; striving for the fair distribution of opportunities, means and treatment.

L

Leadership — The capacity to give direction, motivation and example to others.

→ **see also:** *Servant leadership*

Legal certainty — The assurance that one's rights will be respected; the rule of law.
Liveability — The qualities of an environment that make it healthy and good to live in.
Love — A strong feeling of care, warmth and connection with others.
Loyalty — Being faithful and dependable in relationships, obligations or ideals.
Lucidity — Being clear and intelligible; also inner clarity of thought.

M

Meaning — The value or significance a person attaches to an experience, relationship or activity.

Meaning-making (sense of purpose) — Recognizing meaning and purpose in life.

Mentorship (teaching vocation) — The capacity and willingness to pass on knowledge and to guide others.

Mercy — Showing compassion and offering help to those in need.

Merit — Deservingness earned by having done something good or worthy.

Meticulousness — Careful, precise execution of tasks and judgments.

Mindfulness — Conscious, non-judgmental attention to the present moment.

Note: English/Buddhist-derived term already present in the Dutch source.

Moderation (temperance) — Regulating desires and impulses to make balanced choices.

Modesty — Recognizing one's own limitations and avoiding arrogance.

Moral action — Acting in accordance with ethical principles and convictions.

Moral awareness — The capacity to recognize and understand the ethical aspects of a situation.

Moral compass — An internal reference point for judging good and bad conduct and decisions; an intrinsic motivation to act morally, grounded in critical thinking and one's personal and professional values when facing dilemmas.

Moral courage — Acting on one's convictions despite ridicule, social cost or personal risk.

CULTURAL NOTE *'Morele moed' exists in Dutch as a translation of this English pairing, popularized through Anglo-Saxon professional ethics.*

Moral development — The process of developing ethical competencies, values and skills.

Moral heritage — The values and norms a community passes down across generations.

Moral judgment-action gap — The gap between forming a moral judgment and actually acting on it.

Note: English term already present in the Dutch source.

Moral knowledge — Knowledge of ethical theories, norms and professional codes for moral decisions.

Moral neglect — Failing to recognize the ethical implications of a situation.

Moral proximity — A sense of connection and responsibility towards those who stand closer to us.

Moral rationalization — Rationalizing unethical conduct to make it acceptable.

Moral skills — The capacity to apply ethical considerations in conduct and decision-making.

Moral values — Values that guide morally right action, such as integrity, honesty and justice.

Moralism — The tendency to pass moral judgment on situations or conduct.

Morality — The body of norms and values determining right and wrong in human conduct.

Mores — A custom or usage that serves as a norm for good conduct.

N

Neutrality — Refraining from taking sides, so that all parties are weighed on equal terms — especially relevant to the facilitator's role in guiding moral discussion.

Noblesse oblige — 'Nobility obliges' — a high position brings moral duty.

Note: French maxim already present in the Dutch source.

Nuance — The capacity to acknowledge subtle differences and complex aspects.

O

Obedience (compliance) — A willingness to follow instructions or directions.

Objectivity — Basing judgment on facts and evidence rather than personal bias or preference.

Note: the source has 'Onpartijdigheid' (impartiality) but no standalone 'objectivity'.

Openness — Being transparent and accessible in communication, without hidden agendas.

P

Pang of conscience — Regret or inner suffering from the awareness of having acted wrongly.

Participation — Active involvement in activities, discussion or decision-making.

→ **see also:** *Citizenship*

Passion — Strong emotion and drive for an activity or ideal.

Paternalism — Governing or treating others as if they were incapable of deciding for themselves.

Patience — Being able to stay calm in difficult situations or when facing delay.

Patriotism — Love of and loyalty to one's own country.

Peace — The absence of conflict and the presence of harmony.

People-centredness — A focus on the wellbeing and needs of people.

Perfection — The highest degree of quality, finish or character.

Perseverance — Steadfastly carrying on despite difficulty or setback.

→ **see also:** *Grit*

Personal development — Growth in knowledge, skills and character.

Personal values — Individual convictions about what is good and important, which shape one's choices.

Pioneering — Acting in a forward-looking, innovative way.

Pity — Sympathy for someone who suffers, with a wish to help.

Playfulness — Lightness, humour and creativity in conduct or disposition.

Political correctness — Language and conduct chosen to avoid offending or marginalizing groups; used approvingly as considerate inclusion and pejoratively as censorship or over-sensitivity.

CONTESTED TERM *The oldest term of this cluster (US, late 20th c.). 'Politiek correct' exists in Dutch, but the polemical edge is imported.*

Practical wisdom (prudence) — Acting cautiously and wisely in decisions; sound judgment about what to do.

→ **see also:** *Wisdom, Judgment*

Pragmatism — A practical, goal-oriented approach to problems.

Prejudice — Judging with bias or partiality.

Privacy — The right to personal space and confidentiality.

→ **see also:** *Confidentiality, Boundaries (personal)*

Professional values — Norms and principles that hold within a profession.

Professionalism — Competent, responsible and honest conduct within a profession.

Profundity — The capacity for thorough reflection and deep understanding of situations.

Progressiveness — Striving for renewal and improvement.

Prosperity — The degree of wealth, wellbeing and comfort.

Punctuality — Being accurate and on time, and respecting deadlines.

Punishment — A measure imposed in response to a wrongful act, omission or violation.

Purity — Cleanness, honesty and genuineness in conduct, intention or substance.

Note: Religious/chastity senses of the source deliberately set aside as neutral-descriptive.

Q

Question of conscience — A difficult question that touches someone's moral conviction.

R

Rancour — Bitter, harboured ill-will; the settled refusal to forgive.

→ **see also:** *Forgiveness*

Rationality — Reasonable, logical thinking and action.

Reasonableness — Being guided by reason; being just and equitable.

Reciprocity — Being grounded in mutual exchange or interaction.

Recognition — Valuing and affirming a person's existence, efforts or qualities.

Reliability — Doing what you say, keeping agreements and acting predictably.

Remorse — Regret or contrition over conduct experienced as morally wrong.

Renown — Broadly acknowledged fame or reputation.

Reproach — Pointing out a shortcoming to someone in a censuring way.

Reserve (restraint) — Acting cautiously and thoughtfully, without haste.

Resilience — The capacity to adapt and recover after setback.

Respect — Showing esteem and regard for people, rules or values.

Respectful conduct — Concrete behaviour marked by courtesy, decency and care in interaction.

Responsibility — The duty to see to tasks, consequences or others.

Result — The intended or achieved effect of one's actions and efforts.

Reverence — Deep respect, often for something held higher or more important than oneself.

Right to exist — The right to existence, or recognition of one's worth and presence.

Rivalry — Competition or contest between parties, which may be healthy or destructive.

S

Safeguarding — The institutional duty to protect children and vulnerable people from harm, abuse or neglect.

CULTURAL NOTE *British institutional concept without a single Dutch word; adjacent to 'sociale veiligheid' and 'zorgplicht' but more procedural and protection-specific.*

Sanctity — The quality of being regarded as inviolable, of the highest worth, or religiously exalted.

Scepticism — Critical doubt; withholding assent until claims are examined.

Security (safety) — A state of being protected against danger, harm or threat; a felt sense of shelter.

Self-actualization — The process of personal growth towards one's full potential.

Self-care — Active attention to one's own health and wellbeing.

Self-confidence — The conviction that one can rely on one's own abilities and judgment.

Self-determination — The capacity to make independent decisions about one's own life.

Self-knowledge — Insight into one's own feelings, thoughts and conduct.

Self-respect — A sense of one's own worth; the respect one holds for oneself.

Self-sacrifice — Giving up one's own interests for the sake of others.

Sense of duty — Awareness of one's responsibilities and adherence to them.

→ **see also:** *Duty*

Sense of reality — The capacity to assess a situation soberly and objectively.

Sensitivity — Being open and responsive to subtle signals or emotions.

Servant leadership — Leadership defined by serving and developing those you lead rather than exercising power over them.

CULTURAL NOTE *American (Greenleaf), with Christian roots; 'dienend leiderschap' is a direct translation.*

→ **see also:** *Leadership*

Service — A readiness and capacity to be of help to others.

Shame — An uncomfortable feeling about one's own conduct, seen as morally objectionable.

Note: distinct from guilt: shame is about the person, guilt about the deed.

Shortcoming (falling short) — Failing to fulfil one's duties properly.

Simplicity — Clearness and restraint, without needless complexity.

Sin — The transgression of a divine or moral law; a morally reprehensible act.

Note: religiously charged; in secular teaching contexts use deliberately.

Sincerity — Being honest and authentic in word and deed.

Social safety — An environment in which everyone feels free from (psychological or physical) threat, discrimination or exclusion.

Note: Anglo-Saxon policy more often uses 'psychological safety' (Edmondson) or 'safe environment' — related, not identical.

Solicitude — Attention and care for the wellbeing of others.

Solidarity — A readiness to share responsibility and burdens, and to stand up for one another.

Soundness — Reliability and quality in work and conduct.

Sovereignty — Independence and authority over one's own choices or domain.

Spirituality — The sense or conviction that life has a deeper, often non-material dimension.

Sportsmanship — A fair and respectful attitude in competition or cooperation.

Stability — Steadiness and reliability in circumstances or character.

Stewardship — Responsible care for something entrusted to you — resources, people, the environment — on behalf of others or the future.

CULTURAL NOTE *Anglo-Protestant concept; 'rentmeesterschap' exists (also religious), but 'stewardship' has secularized towards leadership and sustainability.*

Stillness — The absence of noise or bustle; calm and concentration.

Sustainability — The quality of enduring without harming people or the environment; oriented to the future.

Synergy — A joint effect greater than the sum of individual contributions.

T

Tact — Handling people and situations in a sensitive and judicious way.

Temperance — Restraint and balance in desires and conduct.

Note: see also Moderation

Tenderness — Softness, care and warmth in disposition or conduct.

Thoroughness — Careful, meticulous execution of tasks.

Timelessness — The quality of remaining valuable or relevant regardless of time or fashion.

Tolerance — Acceptance of, and respect for, differences in opinion, conduct or culture.

Tradition — Handed-down customs, norms and values that are carried forward.

Transformation — A process of far-reaching change or development.

Transgressive behaviour — Acts that cross another person's physical, emotional or social boundaries and are experienced as unwanted or harmful.

Note: also rendered 'boundary-crossing / boundary-violating behaviour'; English has no exact equal-breadth equivalent — 'misconduct' is too narrow, 'harassment' too legal.

→ **see also:** *Boundaries (personal), Consent*

Transparency — Openness and clarity in communication, intentions or processes.

Trust — Belief in the reliability or good intentions of someone or something.

Truth — The correspondence of statements with reality; sincerity in word and deed.

Truthfulness — Being in accordance with the truth.

Tyranny — The abusive, oppressive exercise of power over others, unchecked by justice or consent.

U

Understanding — The ability to grasp others and their situation.

Uniformity — Sameness and consistency in form, conduct or execution.

Universality — The quality of applying to everyone or everything.

Unscrupulousness — Acting without moral sense, unhindered by moral considerations.

Unwanted behaviour — Behaviour the recipient experiences as unpleasant and sometimes boundary-crossing, such as aggression.

→ **see also:** *Transgressive behaviour, Bullying*

Unwelcome advances (unwanted intimacy) — Unwelcome advances or unwanted physical familiarity.

→ **see also:** *Consent, Boundaries (personal)*

Utilitarianism — The moral theory that the rightness of an act depends on its promoting the greatest happiness for the greatest number.

→ **see also:** *Consequentialist ethics*

V

Valour — The capacity to overcome fear or danger in order to act rightly.

Values & norms — Values: deeper convictions about what matters. Norms: the rules of conduct that follow from them.

Vigour (vitality) — Energy and life-force.

Virtue ethics — An approach to ethics stressing the cultivation of good character traits as the basis for right action.

Virtue signalling — The charge that someone voices a moral position mainly to display their own good character rather than to effect change.

CONTESTED TERM *An accusation, not a value: it presumes insight into another's motive and is itself often used to disqualify sincere moral statements. Originated in British commentary.*

Virtues — Moral traits of character.

Virtuosity — Exceptional skill or mastery in a craft.

W

Whistleblowing — Bringing wrongdoing or illegality inside an organization into the open, often from moral conviction.

Note: 'klokkenluiden' is itself a loan-translation of the English, along with its protective legislation and hero/traitor ambivalence.

Willingness — Being ready to make an effort or to accommodate and support others.

Wisdom — The capacity to judge and decide well on the basis of knowledge and experience.

Woke / wokeness — Originally, alertness to racial and social injustice; now used both approvingly (active awareness of inequality) and pejoratively (dismissing such awareness as performative or excessive).

CONTESTED TERM *The meaning is itself contested — the word turned from in-group virtue to out-group reproach within a decade. Taken into Dutch untranslated, with its Anglo-American culture-war charge.*

Wonder — A feeling of astonishment and admiration.

Word of honour — A promise grounded in integrity and trust.

Worthiness (dignity) — The quality of being respectful and honourable.

Wrath — Intense anger or indignation.

Working with the dictionary — exercises

The dictionary comes alive in use. The exercises below are grouped for the individual, for groups, and for home. Facilitators, trainers and lecturers can adapt any of them freely; most work with any handful of entries.

On your own

A daily word in context

Each day, choose a word from the dictionary. Write a short reflection (five minutes at most) connecting it to something you experienced that day or saw in the news.

A moral diary

For a week, keep a log noting one morally charged situation each day, large or small. Use at least two words from the dictionary to make sense of the experience.

Your personal top five

Choose the five words that mean the most to you. For each, write down why it speaks to you and how it shapes your professional or personal conduct.

Reflection cards

Make cards from dictionary words. Each week, draw one and write a short piece exploring: how does this concept show up in what I do — and where do I struggle with it?

The moral mirror

Choose a word and describe a situation in which you acted in line with it, and one in which you departed from it. What do you learn from the difference?

A letter to yourself

Write yourself a short letter advising how you might put a particular word (say, courage or justice) more into practice.

A word walk

Take a fifteen-minute walk holding a single word in mind. Let thoughts and observations come, and afterwards note what the word came to mean to you along the way.

In a group

Moral speed-dating

Everyone picks a word that speaks to them. In pairs, they take two minutes each to say what it means to them and why. After a few rounds, a shared vocabulary emerges across the group.

A case in words

Bring in a topical or recognizable case (transgressive behaviour, a climate choice, workload). Give small groups a set of five words and ask them to analyse the case using those words. Discuss together how different words widen the view and the debate.

Word chain

One participant names a word. The next immediately links a new word they feel belongs with it and explains why. A chain of words and meanings grows into a shared “moral map”.

The moral dilemma game

Pose a dilemma (for example: “May a doctor share personal information about a patient?”). Ask small groups to choose three words to place at the centre of their reasoning, then compare the different word choices and lines of argument.

A moral dialogue wall

Write key words large on sticky notes or cards and put them on the wall. Ask participants to add words they see connected to their own practice, then discuss the links together: “Why does responsibility hang next to thoroughness?”

The values line

Choose a word (say, responsibility). Ask participants to place themselves physically along a line, from “this is essential to me” to “this means little to me”, and to explain where they stand.

The moral marketplace

Post words around the room. Participants wander and choose which words to pause at; small conversation groups form there to account for their choice.

Shifting perspective through words

Take a case and assign roles (doctor, patient, manager, citizen, and so on). Each role receives three words that colour its perspective. Discuss how this changes the argument.

At home, with family or friends

The moral word at the table

At dinner, choose a word as the theme (say, justice). Everyone shares a small story or example in which that word played a part that day.

Drawing moral cards

Draw a word card blindly and discuss together: what does this mean for our family, friendship or relationship?

Connecting stories

One person tells a story about a moral question. The others each choose a word they feel captures it well, and then you discuss the differences.

The moral time machine

Choose a word (say, loyalty). Everyone tells how it played out in their childhood, how it does now, and how they would want to live it in the future.

Film or book reflection

After a film or book, each person picks a word that best characterizes the story, and you compare the choices.

A moral compliment

Pay someone at the table a compliment by choosing a word that captures how they act, and tell a concrete example.

Three exercises for the English edition

Words one language keeps

Take the entries marked as cultural additions (belonging, safeguarding, stewardship, duty of care). For each, ask: what does English let us say in a single word here, and how would you explain the same idea to someone whose language has no word for it? What does it tell you that a culture coined a word for this?

Describing without judging

Take a contested term (woke, cancel culture, virtue signalling). Ask participants to state, in neutral terms, what it means to those who use it approvingly and to those who use it as a reproach — practising the skill of naming a charged idea without taking a side.

Telling neighbours apart

Give a group a cluster of near-neighbours — shame, guilt and remorse, or compassion, pity and mercy — and a set of short cases. Ask them to decide which word fits which case, and to defend the distinction.

Colophon

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Published by Fontys University of Applied Sciences, Research Group for Ethical Practice (Lectoraat Ethisch Werken)

Edition First edition, December 2025

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